MODULE 7 · SHEET 7A

PASSING DIMINISHED CHORDS

Diminished chords as directed passing devices — each one implies a dominant 7♭9 and creates chromatic tension toward a specific target.

Diminished chords = chromatic passing chord devices that create directed tension toward a specific target. A dim7 chord is a rootless dominant 7♭9 — E7♭9 without the E root = G♯°7 (also written Ab°7). The tritone inside creates identical resolution pull as a dominant 7th chord.

ONLY 3 UNIQUE DIM7 SOUNDS — ALL OTHERS ARE INVERSIONS

GROUP 1	GROUP 2	GROUP 3
C°7	C♯°7	D°7
E♭°7	E°7	F°7
G♭°7	G°7	A♭°7
A°7	B♭°7	B°7
C – E♭ – G♭ – A	*C♯ – E – G – B♭*	*D – F – A♭ – B*

ASCENDING PASSING DIM7 CHORDS IN C MAJOR

NAME	CHORD	IMPLIES (DOM 7♭9)	RESOLVES TO	USE
♯Vdim7	G♯°7	E7♭9	Am7 (vi)	Most common
♯Idim7	C♯°7	A7♭9	Dm7 (ii)	2nd most common
♯IIdim7	D♯°7	B7♭9	Em7 (iii)	Jazz standards
IIIdim7	E°7	C7♭9	Fmaj7 (IV)	Jazz-oriented
♯IVdim7	F♯°7	D7♭9	G7 (V)	Gospel — powerful

DESCENDING PASSING DIM7 — THE SOPHISTICATED OPTION

The descending dim7 is less discussed but equally powerful. The most important: **♭IIIdim7 (E♭°7) descending to Dm7**. Move from a chord to the dim7 a half step above the target, then descend into the target. This creates a smoother, jazzier motion compared to ascending dims.

Example: Fmaj7 → E♭°7 → Dm7 (IV → ♭IIIdim7 → ii)

Note: 7♭9 sounds most naturally resolved when moving to MINOR chords — the minor 3rd of the target absorbs the dissonance smoothly.